

Tracked, Targeted, Trapped

*Digital Risk and Digital Safety for Queer Sex Workers
Facing Surveillance, Harassment, and Arrest Along the
Kenya-Uganda Border*

Trans+

Advocacy, legal support, health access, and digital safety for queer sex workers on the Kenya-Uganda border

This document discusses digital surveillance, police harassment, and violence against LGBTQ people and sex workers. Prepared and published by Trans+.

Executive Summary

Phones and digital platforms have become essential to how queer sex workers along the Kenya-Uganda border find clients, coordinate safety, and stay connected to community while in transit — but the same devices are routinely turned against them, used by police as both evidence and leverage. This paper documents how digital risk intersects with policing and criminalization for this population, and describes Trans+'s approach to building tools that treat security and anonymity as non-negotiable design requirements rather than optional features.

1. The Phone as a Site of Risk

For queer sex workers in this region, a phone is simultaneously an economic necessity, a safety tool, and one of the most significant sources of legal and physical risk they carry. Messages, photos, dating or client-screening app data, and even browser history can be used by police as grounds for a stop, as evidence supporting a same-sex conduct or sex work charge, or simply as leverage in an extortion attempt — an officer who has taken someone's phone can demand payment for its return regardless of what, if anything, is actually on it.

This risk is amplified for people in transit. Crossing a border checkpoint with a phone containing messages related to sex work, dating apps associated with LGBTQ communities, or communications with organizations like Trans+ itself can turn a routine crossing into a prolonged detention. Community members describe adapting behavior accordingly — deleting apps before crossing, using secondary devices, or avoiding digital communication about their situation altogether — adaptations that improve safety in the moment but often at the cost of losing contact with support networks precisely when they are most needed.

2. Documented Patterns of Digital Harassment

- **Phone confiscation as extortion.** Officers confiscate phones during stops and demand payment for their return, sometimes reviewing content in front of the individual as an additional form of intimidation.
- **Content used as pretext.** Dating apps, message threads, or photos are cited as grounds for arrest or as "evidence" of same-sex conduct or sex work, regardless of their actual relevance to any specific offense.
- **Coerced access.** Individuals report being pressured to unlock phones or provide passwords under threat of prolonged detention, effectively removing any meaningful ability to refuse.
- **Outing through device search.** Content found during a search — including contacts, photos, or app data — has reportedly been used to out individuals to family, employers, or landlords, sometimes as a direct threat made by the officer conducting the search.
- **Client-side risk.** Beyond police contact, sex workers also face risks from clients who record or threaten to expose interactions, a risk that is amplified when the underlying work is criminalized and the worker has no safe way to report the threat.

COMMUNITY TESTIMONY (IDENTITY WITHHELD FOR SAFETY)

A community member described being asked to unlock her phone at a checkpoint; the officer scrolled through her messages in front of her and other travelers, then demanded payment to avoid having the contents "reported," despite there being no formal charge or process involved.

3. Why Off-the-Shelf Tools Fall Short

Mainstream client-screening and safety apps, built primarily for contexts where sex work is legal or where anti-LGBTQ criminalization is not a factor, frequently make design assumptions that put users in this region at risk: they may require personal information that could out a user if the device is searched, store data in ways that are recoverable during a forensic review, or lack any mechanism for discreet use in a setting where simply having a particular app installed could itself be treated as suspicious. Generic safety apps also typically assume a stable network and device, assumptions that do not hold for a population that changes phones, crosses borders, and sometimes has devices confiscated entirely.

These gaps are not incidental. For a population where the consequence of exposure can be arrest, violence, or being outed to family, "good enough" security design is not good enough — every design choice needs to be evaluated against the specific, high-stakes threat model this community actually faces.

4. Trans+'s Digital Platforms Model

4.1 Security and Anonymity by Design

Trans+ builds its digital tools starting from the assumption that a device may be searched, a network may be monitored, and exposure carries serious consequences. This shapes concrete design decisions: minimizing what data is collected in the first place, encrypting what must be stored, giving users direct control over what is retained and for how long, and building interfaces that can be used or hidden discreetly.

4.2 Client Screening

Trans+'s client-screening tools allow community members to share information about specific individuals or situations to avoid — including patterns of violence, non-payment, or collaboration with police — while protecting the identity of everyone who contributes information through strong access controls and anonymization.

4.3 Safety Communication and Rapid Alerts

Safety communication tools support discreet check-ins during work, rapid alerts when someone is in danger, and secure reporting of violence or abuse. Where a user chooses, reports can feed directly into Trans+'s legal support and advocacy documentation work, creating a link between an individual safety report and the broader evidence base used in the advocacy described elsewhere in this series.

4.4 Digital Security Training

Beyond the platforms themselves, Trans+ provides digital security training covering device security, safe communication practices with clients and peers, and awareness of what digital traces a person may be leaving in daily life — knowledge that is directly protective given how frequently phone content is used against community members in police encounters.

5. Recommendations

1. **To police oversight bodies:** Prohibit warrantless searches of personal devices during routine stops, and establish clear consequences for officers who use device content as a basis for extortion rather than formal charges.
 2. **To technology and platform companies:** Engage with organizations serving criminalized and high-risk populations when designing safety and dating features, rather than assuming a uniform, low-risk global user base.
 3. **To funders and technical partners:** Support the maintenance and security auditing of purpose-built tools for high-risk populations, recognizing that these tools require ongoing investment to stay ahead of evolving surveillance tactics, not a one-time build.
 4. **To community members:** Where possible, engage with available digital security training and support networks before, not only after, a high-risk crossing or encounter.
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This briefing was researched and prepared by Trans+, an organization led by queer and transgender sex workers working along the Kenya-Uganda border. It draws on documentation gathered through Trans+'s digital safety program, alongside publicly available human rights reporting. For more information, partnership inquiries, or to support this work, please contact Trans+ directly.

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